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Git Ignore and .gitignore

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What is .gitignore?

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The `.gitignore` file tells Git which files and folders to ignore (not track).

This is useful for keeping log files, temporary files, build artifacts, or personal files out of your repository.

- Examples of files to ignore: log files, temporary files, hidden files, personal files, OS/editor files, etc.

The `.gitignore` file itself **is** tracked by Git, so everyone using the repository ignores the same files.

When to Use .gitignore

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Create a .gitignore File

1. Go to the root of your local Git repository.
2. Create a file named `.gitignore`:

Example

```
[user@localhost] $ touch .gitignore
```

Ignoring Folders

To ignore a folder and everything inside it, use a trailing slash:

```
temp/
```

This ignores any folder named `temp` anywhere in your project.

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Wildcards & Patterns

Wildcards let you match many files or folders at once:

- `*` matches any number of characters
- `?` matches a single character
- `[abc]` matches any character in the set
- `[!abc]` matches any character **not** in the set

```
*.tmp      # all .tmp files
my?ile.txt # matches my1ile.txt, myAile.txt, etc.
log[0-9].txt # log1.txt, log2.txt, ... log9.txt
```

Negation (!)

Use `!` to **not** ignore something that would otherwise be ignored. This is called an exception:

```
*.log
!important.log
```

This ignores all `.log` files except `important.log`.

Comments and Blank Lines

Lines starting with `#` are comments and are ignored by Git. Blank lines are also ignored. Use comments to explain your rules:

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```
# Ignore temp folders
temp/
```

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Local & Personal Ignore Rules

If you want to ignore files only for yourself (not for everyone who uses the repository), add them to `.git/info/exclude`. This works just like `.gitignore` but is not shared.

Global .gitignore (User Level)

You can set up a global `.gitignore` file for all your projects. This is great for ignoring OS or editor files everywhere (like `.DS_Store` or `Thumbs.db`):

```
[user@localhost] $ git config --global core.excludesfile ~/.gitignore_glob
```

Then add your patterns to `~/.gitignore_global`.

How to Stop Tracking a File

If you add a file to `.gitignore` but Git is still tracking it, you need to tell Git to stop:

```
[user@localhost] $ git rm --cached filename.txt
```

This removes the file from the repository but keeps it on your computer. Next time you commit, Git will ignore it.

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- If a file is already tracked, use `git rm --cached` to stop tracking it.
- Use comments (`#`) to explain tricky rules for your teammates.
- Use `git status` to see if your ignored files are being tracked.
- Remember: `.gitignore` only affects files that are **not** already tracked by Git.

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Pattern Syntax

Here are some common patterns and how they match:

Pattern	Explanation/Matches	Examples
	Blank lines are ignored	
# text comment	Lines starting with # are ignored	
name	All *name* files, *name* folders, and files and folders in any *name* folder	/name.log /name/file.txt /lib/name.log
name/	Ending with / specifies the pattern is for a folder. Matches all files and folders in any *name* folder	/name/file.txt /name/log/name.log **no match:** /name.log
name.file	All files with the *name.file*	/name.file /lib/name.file
/name.file	Starting with / specifies the pattern matches only files in the root folder	/name.file **no match:** /lib/name.file
lib/name.file	Patterns specifiing files in specific folders are always realative to root (even if you do not start with /)	/lib/name.file **no match:**

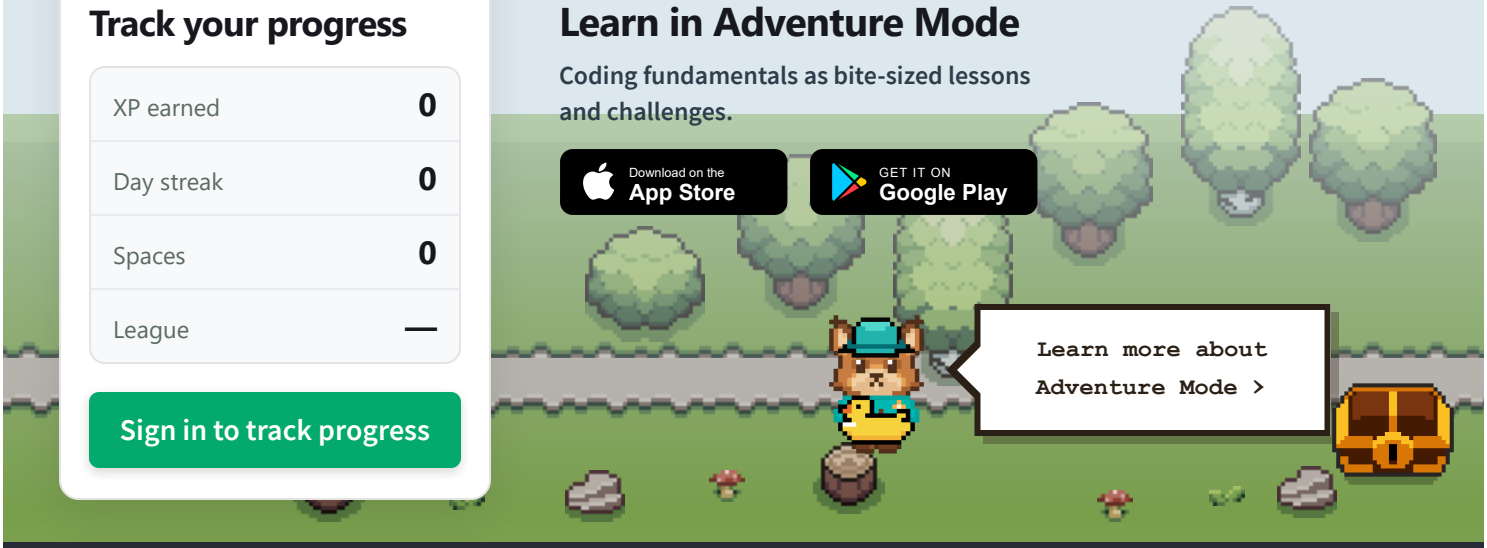
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	that it matches any folder in the repository. Not just on root.	/test/lib/name.file
***/name*	All *name* folders, and files and folders in any *name* folder	/name/log.file /lib/name/log.file /name/lib/log.file
/lib/***/name*	All *name* folders, and files and folders in any *name* folder within the lib folder.	/lib/name/log.file /lib/test/name/log.file /lib/test/ver1/name/log.file **no match:** /name/log.file
**.file*	All files withe *.file* extention	/name.file /lib/name.file
**name/*	All folders ending with *name*	/lastname/log.file /firstname/log.file
name?*.file*	? matches a **single** non-specific character	/names.file /name1.file **no match:** /names1.file
name[a-z]*.file*	[*range*] matches a **single** character in the specified range (in this case a character in the range of a-z, and also be numberic.)	/names.file /nameb.file **no match:** /name1.file
name[abc]*.file*	[*set*] matches a **single** character in the specified set of characters (in this case either a, b, or c)	/namea.file /nameb.file **no match:** /names.file

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*.*file*	All files withe .*file* extention	/name.file /lib/name.file
name/ !*name*/secret.log	! specifies a negation or exception. Matches all files and folders in any *name* folder, except name/secret.log	/name/file.txt /name/log/name.log **no match:** /name/secret.log
*.*file* !*name*.file	! specifies a negation or exception. All files withe .*file* extention, except name.file	/log.file /lastname.file **no match:** /name.file
*.*file* !*name*/*.*file* junk.*	Adding new patterns after a negation will re-ignore a previous negated file All files withe .*file* extention, except the ones in *name* folder. Unless the file name is junk	/log.file /name/log.file **no match:** /name/junk.file

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